Most of the noblemen at court at this time were caught up in the frenzy of chaupar, a dice game that had become an obsession. There were often 200 players at a time playing the game at court and we are told that no one was allowed to go home till he had completed sixteen games, which could last up to three months. If anyone lost their patience, they were to drink a cup of wine, presumably to calm them down. One nobleman lost so much money on bets during a game, and became so angry and vociferous that he greatly annoyed Akbar, so much so that he was told to remove himself to Mecca.*

Serious work continued nonetheless for the Padshah as he continued efforts to overhaul the land revenue system. He appointed Raja Todar Mal to assist the diwan, Muzaffar Khan. Todar Mal suggested a dramatic departure from the earlier method of using a rough estimate of the produce and instead called for actual measurements of all cultivable land by the qanungos.* Tax would be calculated on the basis of the estimated average yield per unit of land, taking into account local variations in productivity in different parganas. The emperor himself was to determine prices of assessed crops separately and the revenue settlement was made directly with the ryot† and so came to be called the ryotwari system.

While Raja Todar Mal would travel the length and breadth of the empire measuring the cultivable lands, over the next ten years, Sikri would become an extraordinary place—a hotbed of ideas and experimentation and creativity possibly unmatched in the world at the time. But at the same time, the Mughal Empire would face many challengers, both in the west and in the east.

The rich province of Gujarat had profited enormously in the fifteenth century from the stable rule of erstwhile advisers to the Delhi Sultanate. As the sultanate itself disintegrated following Timur’s invasion, just one such governor, Zafar Khan, restyling himself Muzaffar Shah, set about bringing prosperity to the region. His descendants made Ahmedabad their capital and developed trade and export thanks to their access to the sea and the large seaports of Cambay and Surat. After Akbar had crushed the power of the mirzas in Jaunpur, the survivors, both Timurid and Afghan, fled to Gujarat seeking the patronage of Muzaffar II, the Sultan of Gujarat, and began defying Mughal authority.

Almost simultaneously with unrest in Gujarat, at the other end of the country, Bengal would flare up too. Ever since the Afghan Lodi dynasty had been crushed by Babur, many Afghan horsemen had galloped east, to the